

Fox is a common name for many species of omnivorous **mammals** belonging to the **Canidae** family. Foxes are small to medium-sized canids (slightly smaller than the medium-sized domestic **dog**), characterized by possessing a long narrow **snout**, and a bushy **tail** (or *brush*).

Members of about **37 species** are referred to as foxes, of which only 12 species actually belong to the *Vulpes* genus of “true foxes”. By far the most common and widespread species of fox is the **red fox** (*Vulpes vulpes*), although various species are found on almost every **continent**. The presence of fox-like **carnivores** all over the globe, together with their widespread reputation for cunning, has contributed to their appearance in **popular culture** and **folklore** in many societies around the world (*see also Foxes in culture*).

The Modern English word “fox” is Old English, and comes from the Proto-Germanic word *fukh* – compare German *Fuchs*, Gothic *fauho*, Old Norse *foa* and Dutch *vos*. It corresponds to the Proto-Indo-European word *puk-* meaning “tail of it” (compare Sanskrit *puccha*, also “tail”). The bushy tail is also the source of the word for fox in Welsh: *llwynog*, from *llwyn*, “bush, grove”. Lithuanian: *uodegis*, from *uodega*, “tail”, Portuguese: *raposa*, from *rabo*, “tail” and Ojibwa: *waagosh*, from *waa*, which refers to the up and down “bounce” or flickering of an animal or its tail. Male foxes are known as dogs or reynards, females as vixens, and young as kits, pups, fuxs, or cubs. A group of foxes is a “skulk”, “troop” or “earth”.

In the wild, foxes can live for up to 10 years, but most foxes only live for 2 to 3 years due to hunting, road accidents and diseases. Foxes are generally smaller than other members of the family Canidae such as wolves, jackals, and domestic dogs. Reynards (male foxes) weigh on average, 5.9 kilograms (13 lb) and vixens (female foxes) weigh less, at around 5.2 kilograms (11.5 lb). Fox-like features typically include a distinctive muzzle (a “fox face”) and bushy tail. Other physical characteristics vary according to habitat. For example, the fennec fox (and other species of fox adapted to life in the desert, such as the kit fox) has large ears and short fur, whereas the Arctic fox has tiny ears and thick, insulating fur. Another example is the red fox which has a typical auburn pelt, the tail normally ending with white marking. Litter sizes can vary greatly according to species and environment – the Arctic Fox, for example, has an average litter of four to five, with eleven as maximum.

Unlike many canids, foxes are not always pack animals. Typically, they live in small family groups, and are opportunistic feeders that hunt live prey (especially rodents). Using a pouncing technique practiced from an early age, they are usually able to kill their prey quickly. Foxes also gather a wide variety of other foods ranging from grasshoppers to fruit and berries. The gray fox is one of only two canine species known to climb trees; the other is the raccoon dog.

Foxes are normally extremely wary of humans and are not usually kept as indoor pets; however, the silver fox was successfully domesticated in Russia after a 45 year selective breeding program. This selective breeding also resulted in physical and behavioral traits appearing that are frequently seen in domestic cats, dogs, and other animals, such as pigmentation changes, floppy ears, and curly tails.

Canids commonly known as foxes include members of the following genera:

Alopex: Arctic fox, although the definitive mammal taxonomy list as well as genetic evidence places it in *Vulpes*, and not as a genus unto itself.

Canis: The Ethiopian Wolf, also called, variously, Semien fox or Semien jackal (though recently renamed to reflect its biological affinity with the gray wolf).

Cerdocyon: Crab-eating fox.

Chrysocyon: Maned wolf (in English), aguara guazú (“big fox” in Guaraní) and zorro rojizo (“reddish fox,” one of several names used by Spanish speakers).

Dusicyon: Falkland Islands fox.

Lycalopex: Six South American species.

Otocyon: Bat-eared fox.

Urocyon: Gray fox, island fox and Cozumel fox.

Vulpes: Including twelve species of true foxes, including the red fox, *V. vulpes*, Tibetan Sand Fox, *Vulpes ferrilata* and their closest kin.

Foxes are omnivores. The diet of foxes is largely made up of invertebrates and other small mammals, reptiles, (such as snakes), amphibians, scorpions, grasses, berries, fruit, fish, birds, eggs, dung beetles, insects and all other kinds of small animals. Many species are generalist predators, but some (such as the crab-eating fox) are more specialist. Most species of fox generally consume around 1 kg of food every day. Foxes cache excess food, burying it for later consumption, usually under leaves, snow, or soil.

The island fox is a critically endangered species.

Foxes are readily found in cities and cultivated areas and (depending upon species) seem to adapt reasonably well to human presence. Red foxes have been introduced into Australia which lacks similar carnivores other than the dingo, and the introduced foxes prey on native wildlife, some to the point of extinction.

*Other fox species do not reproduce as readily as the red fox, and are endangered in their native environments. Key among these are the crab-eating fox (*Cerdocyon thous*) and the African bat-eared fox. Other foxes such as fennec foxes, are not endangered.*

Foxes have been successfully employed to control pests on fruit farms while leaving the fruit intact.

Vulpa Regular & Vulpa Italic & Vulpa Bold



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